

Review: Demographic History or Historical Demography?

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Demographic History or Historical Demography?

A Dharmalingam

India's Historical Demography: Studies in Famine, Disease and Society edited by Tim Dyson; Collected Papers on South Asia, No 8, Centre for South Asian Studies, School of Oriental and African Studies, University of London, Curzon Press, The Riverdale Company, 1989; pp ix + 296.

WHILE an enormous amount of work has been done on the social, economic and political history of India, the coverage of demographic history, and historical demography in particular, is scant and patchy. Whenever concern for historical demography was shown, for instance in the *Cambridge Economic History of India—Volume II: c1757-c1979*, despite the individual merits of the contribution of the Visarias, it was not well integrated into the overall history of India. Given the absence of any prior work on demography to follow on from and a complete absence of interest in the demographic history of the Indian sub-continent, the effort by Kingsley Davis in the late 1940s to sketch the *Population of India and Pakistan* was magnificent and represents, apart from that of the Visarias, the only notable work. However although we demographers accuse the social, political and economic historians of not giving adequate consideration to population, we in turn fail to make use of work done in other fields.

Tim Dyson's encouraging attempt to revive research into the historical demography of India is well-timed; it coincides with the new awakening among Indian historians to the need to prevent misinterpretation of historical facts for political purposes. Some of the well-researched contributions in this book will certainly provoke interest in further research in this discipline.

This book, described by Kingsley Davis in his foreword as a 'variegated case study', attempts to 'enlarge the area of common ground' for future research, apart from its use for social and economic historians, and in addition contributes "to our understanding of the contemporary characteristics of the population of the country". All the papers included in this volume examine the demography of India in one way or another. The scope of the papers varies as much as their methods and approaches. An explicit interdisciplinary approach to studying the interrelationships among economics, politics and demography combines with the application of sophisticated technical demographic tools to arrive at refined vital rates. Each paper deals with a different area at a different time, and a different underlying phenomenon. This diversity necessitates evaluation of the individual contributions

first, before examining the overall contribution made by this volume to understanding the historical demography of modern India.

In an initial overview Tim Dyson seems to press a case for a happy marriage of census data with vital registration, traditional indigenous records and census reports. Largely on the basis of contributions by Lardinois, Commander, Mari Bhat, Clark and himself, Dyson delineates five broad phases of demographic movement in modern India. The first phase is from 1760 to 1820, the second phase starts with the establishment of British hegemony in 1830 and extends up to 1891, the third phase is from 1891 to 1920, the fourth from 1921-1960 and the fifth phase begins in the 1970s. In the first phase the net population growth was zero or negative, in the second there was little growth, in the third there was some growth but less than in the second phase. In the fourth phase the population growth rate was high, and this rate steadily fell in the fifth phase. There is an attempt to explain the demographic features in different phases in terms of economic disruption in the pre-British period, economic stability during and after the colonial and calamities—either natural or those arising out of the British rule. Dyson has ignored the views of the opposite school on Indian economic history (for instance, to mention a few, the views of Irfan Habib, Tapan Raychaudhuri, Bipan Chandra)—that population during the Mughal period did not remain stable; that control of warfare which was mainly held responsible for population growth in 19th century came only after 60 years of warfare from 1757 to 1818 and the 1850's mutiny, and therefore "any growth in output resulting from such improvements would... have to go a long way before the economic *status quo ante-bellum* was surpassed",¹ and that "rationalised taxation, the pattern of commerce, law and order, and judicial system in time led to an extremely regressive (in every sense of the term) agrarian structure".² They do not even rate mention in the bibliography or a footnote. Leaving this aside, the demographic schema itself appears to be of limited use not only because the underlying process of development is not considered adequately, but also, as the author agrees, because of incoherence in space and time of the studies included in the

book. However one must appreciate the author's early caution in the note to the schema that it is 'tentative, incomplete and highly simplified' and his acknowledgement of the need for much elaboration.

Dyson's construction of Indian demographic history is largely based on such factors as famine, disease, and drought, leaving out the role played by the socio-economic and political systems in determining the incidence or the severity of such so-called natural calamities. He assigns a secondary role to the nature of the economic system: "thus changes in mortality level can rarely be taken simply as reflections of economic changes *per se*, though clearly such changes can play a role" (p 10).

The next chapter is by Roland Lardinois on rural Tamil Nadu covering the period from about 1780 to around 1830. Lardinois makes praiseworthy efforts to analyse unreliable data with the utmost care. Using the lists of villages and district maps prepared by the colonial government for estimating and collecting land revenue, Lardinois first establishes that during the period under focus, there was widespread desertion of villages in rural Tamil areas, particularly in the coastal and irrigated valleys. This desertion seems to have been accompanied, as Lardinois argues, by a considerable reduction in the area cultivated, and disruption and decay of irrigation systems. These three factors in turn resulted in stagnation in agricultural production. Lardinois explains these facts in terms of war, famine and pestilence. Most of the statistics used come from the collector's report which the author uses with caution.

War, apart from disrupting cultivation, diverted both grain and human and animal resources from civilian use to army use. Lardinois quotes from the collector of Coimbatore's report that: "The ploughs stood still, ripe grains decayed on the ground, and much was lost for the want of cattle to water it, owing to the public service employing their bullocks" (p 26). Though the author was able to record the periods of war, famine and epidemics, there were not enough data to permit the enumeration of the casualties. However, using the population count available for all Tamil districts for the period 1821-26, and for the periods 1778-79 and 1792 for Thanjavur and Salem districts, Lardinois argues that 'it is hard to believe that the population grew significantly'. By dismissing migration as only a part of the explanation for the large-scale desertion of villages in the late eighteenth century Lardinois implies that the interaction of war, economic crisis, famine, and pestilence resulted in huge loss of human life; so he concludes that the apparent depopulation seen in Thanjavur and Salem during the period 1780-1830 may be representative of the entire region. However he leaves the following question without adequate

explanation: why were there large differences in the level of desertion between different districts, and within a given district (for instance Balaghat and Dindigul)? Nevertheless the contribution of Lardinois should not be underestimated.

Simon Commander has examined the interaction of economic and demographic factors in the evolution, over the nineteenth century, of the Doab region, comprising the alluvial plain between the Jumna and the Ganges that stretches down from Saharanpur: his data sources used are both primary and secondary. The mobile nature of this population does not negate the possibility that the Doab region experienced population decline in the late eighteenth century. Population and agricultural production seemed to have increased significantly over the nineteenth century; more than 70 per cent of the population were engaged in agricultural production. Particularly up to 1870 the population growth was phenomenal and even exceeded the growth of agricultural production. Commander notes that the strongest growth was in the decade 1860-70 and the taxation burden was heaviest during the first forty years of colonial rule which resulted in high levels of revenue defaults and auction sales. In the later part of the nineteenth century growth in agricultural production slowed through failure to raise land productivity and through increased population density. The fluctuation of output, coupled with famine and disease, the author argues, affected the population according to their purchasing power. The more backward areas were the worst-hit during the epidemic years and it was mostly the poorer classes in both town and countryside who were famine victims; therefore "To that extent, the mortality focus of later periods of dearth and disease was more socially discriminatory". Commander mentions that the area under cash and export crops was relatively high during 1800-30 and did not expand later in the nineteenth century, but does not use this as an explanation of food shortages and consequent famine. He seems to believe that there was a high fertility regime because of low age at marriage and no contraceptive use; but these are insufficient explanations unless accompanied by the argument for relative increase in fecundity in Doab area as a result of high nutritional status. A shortened birth interval due to high infant mortality could also have facilitated the prevalence of a high fertility regime. Commander, however, finishes his paper with an interesting conclusion:

Inequalities in land endowments and, increasingly, in access to labour markets became more pronounced [over the nineteenth century]. For if much of nineteenth century growth was of the 'old style'—through extensive means—this was closely linked to the highly skewed distribution of assets and income that has subsequently come to be a hallmark of the Indian agrarian economy (p 69).

The next two papers, by Mari Bhat and Alice Clark, use a new methodology called 'variable r ', to estimate demographic parameters using census age distributions. While the aim of Clark in using this advanced methodology was to give new directions to the mortality history of colonial India, Bhat chose to reassess and challenge the previous estimates of fertility and mortality. Bhat focuses his analysis on the period 1881-1961 for India as a whole. He argues powerfully that his revised estimates of fertility and mortality come closer to the true values than the previous estimates, which were exaggerated because, Bhat claims, the age distributions used for calculations, though smoothened, were distorted by severe age misstatements. He makes the interesting but debatable claims that life expectancy at birth at the beginning of this century was greater than in other estimates, that adult mortality was higher than mortality at young ages, and that male life expectancy at birth did not exceed that of females until the 1950s. The weapon, but a blunt one too in my view, with which he substantiates these findings is 'effects of age misstatements'. Even if one agrees that misstatement of age is so great as to bias the vital rates, it is hard to accept his strong assumption that marital fertility remained constant during the period 1881-1961. Bhat keeps reminding the reader that this assumption is strong in the light of other evidence which shows that marital fertility increased in the later part of the period under consideration; but he does not anticipate the possibility that the small deviations from those of others in his estimated values may have been the artefact of his strong assumption, as would have been the case with severe age misstatement. Finally one might have expected that this technology would produce some appreciably different estimate yet the crude birth rate at the beginning of this century was 47 births per 1000 population according to Bhat's estimation, 48 according to Davis's estimate made more than three decades ago and 49 according to Coale and Demeny's estimate;³ Bhat goes on to explain a difference of 0.2 percentage points between his and the other two estimates. At this point it is useful to recall Pethe's recent observation:

There has been little attempt on their [technical demographers'] part to throw light on the basic socio-economic and cultural under-currents which manifest themselves in these interrelationships and indices. In other words, they have explained only *what*, not *how* and *why* of demographic social dynamics... The quantitative demographers have to explore more imaginative and innovative techniques so as to disentangle the cobwebs of the demographic and social situation.⁴

This is what Alice Clark has tried to do in her paper. She argues that her study "challenges some parts of the interpretation of the period as one of steady economic development. For the development of the infrastructure which would later bring

economic advancement, it appears that human beings may have paid a heavier price than we realised" (p 120). She focuses on the former United Provinces in the north, Bombay in the west and Madras presidency in the south. Data limitation forces her to confine her analysis to a fifty-year period from 1881 to 1931. Clark adapts her methodology quite successfully to suit the mortality crisis periods and non-crisis periods, which in turn helps in understanding the phenomenon of relatively higher mortality experience among adults than among children in times of crisis. During the period under consideration the overall mortality level in Bombay and United Provinces was higher than that of Madras, possibly because of endemic malaria and regular harvest failures in the north and west compared to the south. Clark's new life tables challenge the belief that female status relative to male status was materially better in the south than in the north. The new life tables, if correct, mean that in United Provinces and Bombay female life expectation at birth exceeded that of males during the crisis decades whereas in Madras males outstripped females in every decade and the gap keeps widening. The unchanged pattern of discrimination between the values of male and female lives, the author maintains, ensured that in the period of declining mortality the decline was slower for females than for males. Clark further observes that "With increased overall opportunity to survive, these patterns of discrimination could become even more refined, more selective" (p 144). It is worth noting Sen's brief account of Indian women in the colonial heritage:

While large numbers of both women and men were impoverished by these [inherent inequality and poverty-creating character of economic and political] processes, women tended to suffer more. When private property in land was introduced, for example, women more often than men lost traditional land use-right. It was women's labour that tended to be unpaid and ill-specified under systems of tenancy and debt peonage. When traditional manufactures decayed, it was often female employment and incomes that were affected most, as for example in food processing. Women often left with meagre resources to feed and care for children, the aged, and the infirm when men migrated or were conscripted into forced labour by the colonialists.⁵

Though this interesting demographic picture is not properly placed in the overall social structure of the time, which Clark seems to promise in her introductory section, the study itself is illuminating and challenging.

Dyson quite persuasively argues against the stigma attached by other researchers to the vital registration data in analysing the demographic history of India. He takes the former Berar province which comprises the districts of Akola, Amraoti, Buldana and Yeotmal of Maharashtra state, and in the first section of his paper builds a defence of the good registration data of the Berar.

By efficiently using the census commissioners' reports and other primary sources and also by applying internal consistency tests Dyson successfully establishes the relatively good quality of vital registration data since the inception of such apparatus. In fact one of the strong reasons for selecting Berar was that it was thought to have abnormally good data. He then derives the adjusted annual crude death, birth and infant mortality rates with special treatment given to mortality crisis years. Using these vital rates Dyson simulates life expectation, total fertility rate and age distribution and maintains that the simulated values are reasonably robust to the assumptions involved.

Both the vital registration rates and the simulated rates follow the general overall pattern of India and thereby Dyson highlights the importance of making use of vital registration data. He maintains that Berar's fertility 'rarely exceeded moderate levels' and locates 'the onset of demographic transition in the mid 1940s'.

Except for some passing references to food availability and price rises at times of epidemic and famine, Dyson ignores the economic outcome of the political structure and its effect on the demographic structure. In the introductory section, he gives the impression of equating the rich alluvial soil of Berar and cultivation of commercial crops with huge wealth. This is hard to accept without qualification, given the increasing economic differentiation in the later part of colonial rule, the harsh attitudes of the colonial regime in collecting the maximum revenue possible, and its disinclination to postpone collection of revenue arrears sufficiently long after economic and mortality crisis periods.

Dyson could have been expected to explain what role the relatively advanced economic development and efficient administration in Berar played in obtaining reasonably good vital registration data and shaping the demography of Berar, but he only poses the question at the end of his paper. Nevertheless his analysis is thought provoking, and lays a strong foundation for the fruitful use of registration data in future research in other parts of India.

Deborah Guz in her contribution explores the famines of 89-97 and 1899-1900 in Hissar district of Punjab, their devastating effects on fertility and mortality and the facilitating role played by the colonial government's Famine Code. She argues with the help of vital registration data that the effects of the two famine periods on fertility and mortality were adverse not only during the famine period but also in the subsequent years. Though mortality among young and old increased during the crisis years, the percentage share of children was lower because of reduced births during famine years. This supports to some extent what Mari Bhat observed regarding age structure of mortality in the early part of the twentieth century. Very unfavourable sex ratios for

females particularly during crisis periods reaffirm the fact that when access to food within a household falls below a critical level the most disadvantaged victims are women.

Guz's evaluation of government famine relief policies is noteworthy. Despite improvements in infrastructural facilities during colonial rule, the government's 'wait and see' policy and *laissez-faire* principles, the author argues, must have "deterred it from pursuing more direct preventive measures on observing early warning signals of possible impending crisis" (p 217). In this context Sen's observation helps to highlight the issue powerfully: "the causation of hunger as well as its prevention may materially depend on how property rights are structured. If a set of property rights leads, say, to starvation, as it well might, then the moral approval of these rights would certainly be compromised severely".⁶ Thus while children aged more than ten years had to work in relief works, old and young dependents had to be at work sites to get free allowances. Suggestions to remedy this situation which would affect the health of children were met with outright rejection and denial. The higher mortality among children, therefore, has to be seen in this context. Though in the first famine the poor were largely deprived of purchasing power, in the second the rich as well as the poor suffered, partly through the revenue policies followed by the government, which "exacerbated the situation by collecting the arrears of revenue for 1896-97, depriving the people of the necessary resources for recovery and rehabilitation. When famine reappeared its impact was harder and more widespread, reaching the richer as well as the poorer classes" (p 218). Guz's effort to place the famine demography in the economic and political context has undoubtedly contributed to our understanding of the historical demography of India.

Following Guz, Ian Mills examines the influenza epidemics of 1918-19 with particular emphasis on Bombay presidency. After a brief investigation into the origin and spread of the pandemic Mills follows the conventional pattern of estimating the levels of mortality by geographic regions and by age and sex differentials. During the epidemic years India lost almost 20 million of its citizens, which resulted in a life expectation at birth of 6 years. Age and sex differentials are similar to those which Guz observed in Hissar with relatively more adults and more women vulnerable to the pandemic. The birth rate in the years following the influenza was lower than average for the normal years. This was brought about by mortality, acting through increased maternal mortality and the dissolution of marriages by the death of one or both partners; and morbidity, acting through coital frequency, increased still births, and the postponement of marriages. Paucity of mortality or morbidity data by social and economic class, the author claims, permitted only a perfunctory treatment of class effects on mortality. Mills contends that class could have affected mortality

through access to medical treatment and level of malnutrition. Without delving into the socio-economic structure and differentiation in different parts of India, Mills however observes that "The role of malnutrition, in relation to the existence of famine in the north, west and centre of India may also help explain... the geographical distribution of mortality within India (providing an alternative to the pre-existing hypothesis based on climatic differences)" (p 253).

David Arnold in his article on cholera mortality in British India argues that a better understanding of a general decline in cholera mortality since the beginning of the twentieth century, and a significant decline after independence, demand consideration of the nature, manner of occurrence and the different factors which influenced its incidence and distribution. Though there is a link between famine and cholera, famines "represented but one extreme illustration of the ways in which infected water supplies, human mobility, and the problems of rural health, sanitation and poverty in general combined together to produce high levels of cholera mortality in India" (p 271).

Arnold argues powerfully that the decline in cholera mortality in twentieth century India was mainly brought about by improvements in sanitary and medical measures while inoculation, bacteriological change and the declining incidence of famine since 1908 (excluding 1943) also played their role in "breaking the links in the epidemiological chain". Reluctance on the part of the public to accept western medical and sanitary measures; Indian medical experts' lack of confidence in western medicine until the beginning of twentieth century; and unwillingness to invest in public health due to "the financial and political interest of the colonial regime in the extraction of wealth from India" (p 274), made early reduction in cholera mortality difficult. Arnold's con-

LAND IN WEST BENGAL

By
TODARMAL

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tribution emphasises the vital role historically played by sanitary intervention in shaping the health and structure of a population; and the failure of India's rulers to provide adequate safe drinking water and efficient sewerage systems even after 40 years of independence is evidence of this historical fact.

The book concludes impressively with the final chapter on comparative historical demography by Nigel Crook whose profound understanding of his subject is unquestionable. He contends, with evidence from Japan and China, that it is difficult to comprehend the universalistic application of the high fertility levels observed in pre-transition eastern Europe and central Asia, to all far eastern countries. Instead, as some of the papers in this book reveal, the pre-transition fertility level was moderate in India as it was in China and Japan. Crook argues that

To put the point as conservatively as possible, there is enough evidence of conscious fertility choice in pre-modern Asian societies to question the view that the well-documented fluctuating fertility rates were caused by exogenous factors such as the biological effects of starvation. Historical oriental fertility was neither universally high, or universally static; nor, I suspect, was it universally uncontrolled (p 288).

His view that there was conscious fertility control particularly in pre-transition India, however, is debatable. One cannot evade the point that starvation and economic crisis, which are manifestations of the underlying economic and political structures, produce not only adverse biological effects but also behavioural adaptations. These adaptations, such as postponement of marriage and reduced coital frequency, were means used to prolong survival rather than to reduce fertility. Mills in his paper convincingly argues for both social and biological effects of famine and influenza which in turn influence behavioural factors that suppress or increase fertility. These mechanisms were forced upon the underprivileged by the unfavourable environment, rather than voluntarily adopted.

This takes us to the final question, whether the existing paradigm of 'historical demography' is sufficient to interpret the historical facts of population in relation to social, economic and political realities; and if so where to place 'the Historical Demography of India' produced by Tim Dyson. If the predominance of particular social science paradigms is determined by the strength of existing social, economic and political forces, and if change in those paradigms is conditioned by changes in those underlying forces, then is it not time to refine the existing paradigms?

The Multilingual Demographic Dictionary narrowly defines historical demography as a discipline in demography which 'deals with populations of the past for which written records are available'. The *International Encyclopedia of Population*

gives a still narrowly refined definition of the application of current methods of analysis to records assembled in the past often for nondemographic purposes, or at least for purposes that were different from those of present-day demographers⁷

and makes a distinction between demographic history and historical demography:

While demographic history seeks to provide an accurate accounting of population change in the past, historical demography is more precisely defined by its data sources and the way they are used to investigate the past.⁸

However the distinction is obscure and does not really place the issue of population in the context of social, economic and political superstructures of a society. Historical demography is abstract if it is not studied in relation to the social environment. In this context it is worth noting the long-running debate on Robert Brenner's thesis on the role of class in pre-industrial European economic development wherein demography was one of the central issues. Given the increased polarisation in Indian society after independence, it would be interesting to know whether the population structure played any role in the process of economic differentiation which was under way during the colonial period; and to what extent the differentiation itself gave rise to a particular demographic regime. Not only does this lead to a better understanding of the past but also correct facts can help in discerning the present and future. It is time, therefore, that the discipline of historical demography was expanded to take on an all-inclusive character. As Crook observes in his concluding section,

What we are less able to explain are those interrelating forces, interactions between family, class, and nation, that gives [sic] rise to the long-term demographic trends. Such an explanation would not only be of historical interest (p 294).

This volume under review is an attempt in that direction. Most of the contributions in this book have tried to show the demographic effects in the context of the economic and political forces that were in operation at the time. Some have done so with extreme success. It is to be hoped that the lead of this interesting and well-researched work will be followed by others for a better understanding of the past and present demography in a historical context. The merits of this book warrant a place on the shelf of every social scientist.

Notes

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1 Tapan Raychaudhuri (1968), 'A Re-interpretation of Nineteenth Century Indian

Economic History?' *Indian Economic and Social History Review*, 5, 1:77-100, p 89.

2 Bipan Chandra (1968), 'Re-interpretation of Nineteenth Century Indian Economic History?', *Indian Economic and Social History Review*, 5, 1:35-75, p 47.

3 Ansley J Coale and Paul Demeny (1967), *Manual IV: Methods of Estimating Basic Demographic Measures from Incomplete Data*, New York, United Nations.

4 Vasant P Pethe (1989), 'Beyond Demography' in S N Singh, M K Premi, P S Bhatia and Ashish Bose (eds), *Population Transition in India*, Vol 1, prepared for the Indian Association for the Study of Population, New Delhi, B R Publishing Corporation, p 9.

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6 Amartya Sen (1988), 'Property and Hunger', *Economics and Philosophy*, 4, 1:57-68, p 60.

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